

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN SUDAN

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in Sudan must be pursued in the shadow of one of the world's worst wars and displacement crises — largely through the international, the United Nations, the diaspora, and the communities where it is safe, and always protecting anyone inside — and yet it turns on a resource of quiet global importance: the acacia woodlands of the **gum belt**, which supply most of the world's gum arabic and hold back the advancing desert. Sudan is a vast Sahelian and Nile-valley nation, riven since 2023 by a catastrophic conflict, but stretched across its south-central lands lies a belt of acacia trees the size of France whose sap is a hidden ingredient in a great share of the world's soft drinks, sweets, cosmetics, and medicines, whose harvest sustains the livelihoods of millions, and whose canopy is a living wall against the Sahara. That belt — a global commodity, a rural livelihood, and a bulwark against the desert, all at once — is the distinctive ground of environmental effort here, joined to the Nile and its war-damaged dams, the gold whose mining scars the land and finances the war, and the desert pressing down from the north. There is no landmark victory to point to, and the nation is at war. But the levers, running largely through the international and the community, are real.

In a nation at war, the tools run largely from outside — the international, the UN, the diaspora — and through the communities where safe, protecting anyone inside, and they are real. The distinctive lever is the gum belt's standing as a **global commodity**: it supplies most of the world's gum arabic, so the **world's buyers and bodies, and the traceable, conflict-free supply chain** they can be pressed to require, are a powerful means to protect the belt and keep it out of the war economy — the same supply-chain and reputational lever that reaches any globally traded resource. The **gold's mercury and its conflict-financing** can be confronted through the contamination and the responsible-sourcing and conflict-gold frameworks — the harm measured and the sourcing pressed. The **Nile and its war-damaged dams** can be safeguarded through the transboundary water frameworks and the dam-safety accountability the world can demand. And the **international, UN, diaspora, and community-where-safe channels** offer real avenues a war-torn state cannot. These tools are general, not tied to one harm: the supply-chain and reputational lever, the sourcing and contamination frameworks, the transboundary and accountability channels, and the international and diaspora avenues reach any of the country's harms, with the gum belt the central case. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The country is at war and much of it dangerous, so most work runs from outside, protecting anyone inside absolutely. The gum belt is disrupted by looting, smuggling, and conflict-financing, and undervalued even in peace, and the people who harvest it and who mine the gold do so to survive, so they must never be blamed or punished, only supported. The gold is entangled in the war economy. The dams are damaged and the desert advancing, driven by forces beyond the nation's power. And progress will be slow and partial amid such a crisis. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — the gum belt protected and kept conflict-free through the buyers and the supply chain; the gold's mercury and conflict-financing confronted through the frameworks; the Nile and dams safeguarded through the transboundary and accountability channels — through the international, UN, diaspora, and community-where-safe channels, never punishing the poor, and protecting everyone inside. Above all, protect the people.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot safely confront armed actors or work openly in a war zone, and you must never endanger anyone inside or blame the desperate. What can be done runs largely from outside and through the world's stake in Sudan's resources: press the world's buyers and a traceable, conflict-free supply chain to protect the gum belt and keep it out of the war economy; confront the gold's mercury and conflict-financing through the contamination and sourcing frameworks; safeguard the Nile and its damaged dams through the transboundary and dam-safety channels; and work the international, UN, diaspora, and safe-community avenues — all with great care, supporting the poor rather than blaming them, and protecting everyone inside.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Sudan is among the hardest and most dangerous settings in this guide, and honesty about that is the first and gravest discipline. The country is at war and much of it dangerous, so most work runs from outside; the gum belt is disrupted by looting, smuggling, and conflict-financing; the gold is entangled in the war economy; the dams are damaged and the desert advancing; and progress will be slow and partial. This is not a fight for open, domestic confrontation. It is careful, largely international work whose realistic prize is the gum belt protected and kept conflict-free, the gold's harms confronted, and the Nile safeguarded — while the poor are supported, not blamed, and everyone inside is protected absolutely.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Domestic authority is fractured by war, so the decisions a careful effort can reach run largely through the world and its stake in Sudan's resources: the **global buyers and bodies** of the gum arabic and the gold; the **traceability and responsible-sourcing frameworks** that govern them; the **transboundary Nile institutions**; and the **international, UN, and diaspora bodies**. The communities, where safe, hold real standing over the belt they harvest. Keep clear of the armed actors and the conflict zones, and map which international or safe-community channel reaches a harm before spending a week on it.

How the Harm Moves — and Where You Jump In

The gum flows out through a global supply chain; the gold funds the war and poisons the land; the Nile's dams sit damaged; the desert advances. You enter at the world's buyers and the traceable, conflict-free supply chain for the gum belt; at the contamination and responsible-sourcing frameworks for the gold; at the transboundary and dam-safety channels for the Nile; and through the international, UN, and diaspora avenues throughout. Enter from outside, carefully, supporting the poor and protecting everyone inside.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the gum: from the acacia belt through the traders to the global buyers, and whether the chain is traceable and conflict-free. Follow the gold: the mercury that poisons the land and the revenue that funds the war, and the sourcing frameworks that could reach it. Follow the Nile: the damaged dams and the transboundary water. Follow the desert: how it advances, and how the belt holds it back. The leverage lies in the supply chain and buyers, the sourcing and contamination frameworks, and the transboundary and accountability channels.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Domestic oversight is shattered by war, so the watchers a careful case engages are the global buyers and sourcing bodies, the transboundary Nile institutions, the international and UN frameworks and donors, the diaspora, and the safe communities. The gum belt's global value and the gold's traceable chain give the international watchers real handles, from outside.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Sudanese effort safely confronts the war economy or works openly amid the conflict, and honesty requires saying so — the country is at war. What the careful, largely international tools can deliver is the gum belt protected and kept conflict-free, the gold's harms confronted, and the Nile safeguarded. The single most decisive move is **pressing the world's buyers and a traceable, conflict-free supply chain to protect the gum belt**, because the world has a real stake in the gum arabic it depends on, and because that pressure can be applied from outside without endangering anyone inside. The supply chain and buyers are the distinctive lever; the sourcing and contamination frameworks the gold's confrontation; the transboundary and accountability channels the Nile's safeguard; the international and diaspora avenues the reach. The realistic prize is real, pursued from outside and safely.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the gum belt's disruption, the gold's mercury and conflict-financing, the Nile's damaged dams, the desert's advance. **What framework reaches it?** — the buyers and supply chain, the sourcing and contamination frameworks, the transboundary channels. **Who is responsible abroad?** — the global buyers, the sourcing bodies, the transboundary institutions. **What supports the poor?** — the fair livelihoods for the harvesters and miners, never blame. **How is everyone inside protected?** — the overriding question. Pick the harm the international frameworks and the world's stake can reach safely, from outside.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case carefully, largely from outside. **Layer one: the harm** — the gum belt's disruption and conflict-financing, the gold's mercury, the Nile's damaged dams, the desert's advance, documented by satellite, international monitoring, and safe community sources. **Layer two: the framework and the responsible party** — the world's buyers and the traceability requirements, the sourcing and contamination frameworks, the transboundary Nile institutions. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which international, diaspora, or safe community channel to engage, and the absolute discipline of never endangering anyone inside, never blaming the poor, and keeping clear of the war. A case built on the world's stake in the gum belt and the traceable supply chain, carried from outside, is one that can move the responsible parties and keep everyone safe.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **gum record**: the belt's disruption, the trade routes, the buyers, and whether the chain is traceable and conflict-free. Gather the **gold record**: the mercury contamination, the war-financing, the sourcing frameworks. Gather the **Nile record**: the damaged dams, the transboundary water. Gather the **desert record**: the advance, and the belt that holds it. Gather the **channel record**: the international and UN

bodies, the buyers, the diaspora, the safe communities. Gather the **safety discipline**: confirm nothing endangers anyone inside or blames the poor.

STEP 3: BUILDING THE INTERNATIONAL AND DIASPORA COALITION

The coalition here is international, diaspora, and — only where entirely safe — community, because open domestic work is dangerous. Build it from the **global buyers and sourcing bodies** of the gum and the gold, who can require a clean chain; the **international and UN frameworks and monitors**; the **Sudanese diaspora**, who document and advocate from outside; and the **communities and harvesters**, only where safe. Frame everything around the world's stake in the gum belt and the harms to be confronted, and the fair livelihoods of the harvesters and miners; never blame the poor; keep clear of the war; and protect anyone inside absolutely.

STEP 4: THE SUPPLY CHAIN, THE SOURCING FRAMEWORKS & THE TRANSBOUNDARY CHANNELS — WORKING LARGELY FROM OUTSIDE

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained by war and danger, so the prize is the belt protected, the gold confronted, and the Nile safeguarded — from outside.

The Gum Belt and the Supply Chain

The distinctive lever is the gum belt's standing as a **global commodity**: it supplies most of the world's gum arabic, so the **world's buyers and a traceable, conflict-free supply chain** can be pressed to protect it and keep it out of the war economy. Press the buyers and the chain — and support the harvesters, never blame them.

The Gold and the Nile

The **gold's mercury and conflict-financing** can be confronted through the contamination and responsible-sourcing and conflict-gold frameworks, and the **Nile and its damaged dams** through the transboundary water frameworks and the dam-safety accountability. Press the sourcing frameworks and the transboundary channels.

The International, UN & Diaspora Channels

The **international, UN, diaspora, and community-where-safe channels** carry the whole effort — the reach a war-torn state cannot supply. Pursued together — the supply chain and buyers, the sourcing and transboundary frameworks, and the international and diaspora channels — these levers protect the belt and confront the harms from outside, while protecting everyone inside.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always from outside and carefully. **For the global buyers**: here is gum arabic you depend on, at risk and entangled in war — require a clean, traceable chain. **For the sourcing frameworks**: here is gold whose mercury and war-financing your rules should reach. **For the transboundary institutions**: here is a Nile and damaged dams to safeguard. **For the international and UN bodies**: here is a resource of

global value and a people to support. **For the world:** here is a treasure — and a livelihood for millions — worth protecting. **The golden rule:** press the buyers and the supply chain for the gum belt, the sourcing frameworks for the gold, the transboundary channels for the Nile; support the poor; keep clear of the war; and protect everyone inside.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with the greatest care, and largely through international and diaspora channels. Frame any attention around **the global treasure and the people who depend on it:** the gum belt the world relies on, disrupted by war and undervalued even in peace, and the harvesters whose livelihoods it sustains — never in a way that endangers anyone inside or blames the poor. Carry it through the international press, the diaspora networks, and the buyers and UN monitors. A few cautions govern everything: never expose anyone inside; never blame the poor; keep clear of the war; and let the world's stake in the gum belt and the traceable chain carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message careful, international, protective of everyone inside, and never blaming the poor.

8A — To a global buyer of gum arabic: press for a traceable, conflict-free supply chain that protects the belt.

8B — To a sourcing or certification body: require the clean, conflict-free sourcing of the gum or the gold.

8C — On the gold's mercury: document the contamination and press the responsible-sourcing and conflict-gold frameworks.

8D — To a transboundary Nile institution: raise the damaged dams and the shared water.

8E — To an international or UN body: present the harm to a resource of global value and request engagement.

8F — On fair livelihoods: propose the support the harvesters and miners need, never blame.

8G — To the diaspora: coordinate the documentation and advocacy from outside.

8H — To the international public: tell the story of a global treasure, and the people who depend on it, at risk in war — exposing no one inside.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: document the gum belt's disruption or the gold's mercury by satellite and international monitoring; identify the buyers or sourcing bodies; write the one-page case grounded in the world's stake and the traceable chain. **The fastest-moving levers:** the buyers and supply chain for the gum belt, and the sourcing frameworks for the gold. **Emergency action:** where a shipment or buyer is identifiable, the supply chain and sourcing frameworks are the sharpest, safest handles, all from outside. Throughout, expose no one inside, blame no one poor, and keep clear of the war.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but shattered by war. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not open confrontation, but the gum belt protected and kept conflict-free, the gold confronted, the Nile safeguarded. Lean on the levers the tilt cannot erase: the world's buyers and the traceable supply chain, the sourcing and contamination frameworks, the transboundary and accountability channels, the diaspora and international bodies. And accept the honest limits — the war disrupts everything, the gold funds it, the desert advances — while still protecting the belt from outside, supporting the poor, and protecting everyone inside.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CONFLICT — AND WHO IS AT RISK

Here the danger is not hidden corruption but a catastrophic war, armed actors who loot the belt and mine the gold to fund themselves, and a shattered state. Respond only through the **careful, international, and diaspora channels**: the buyers and supply chain, the sourcing and transboundary frameworks, the international and UN bodies, the safe communities. Never through open confrontation, and never touching the war. **On safety and protection**: this note matters greatly here and governs everything. Sudan is a nation at war, its state divided and much of it consumed by one of the world's worst humanitarian crises. Work through the international, UN, diaspora, and — only where entirely safe — community channels; never expose or endanger anyone inside; never blame the poor who harvest the gum or mine the gold to survive; and keep clear of the war. Protection is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, carefully and largely from outside. The documented gum-belt disruption feeds the buyers and supply-chain pressure; the gold's mercury feeds the sourcing frameworks; the Nile's dams feed the transboundary channels; the diaspora advocacy and the fair-livelihoods support run alongside. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harms by satellite and monitoring; **months two onward**, press the buyers, the sourcing frameworks, and the transboundary institutions, and engage the diaspora and donors; **through the long effort**, sustain the protection and the support. The core discipline: internationally pressed, community-safe, never blaming the poor, and protective of everyone inside.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Sudan is among the hardest and most dangerous grounds in this guide, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim the war economy can be safely confronted from within, or that open domestic work is possible, or that a landmark victory exists — none of that is true, and the country is at war. What it claims is real: that the gum belt supplies most of the world's gum arabic, so the world's buyers and a traceable, conflict-free supply chain can be pressed to protect it and keep it out of the war economy; that the gold's mercury and conflict-financing can be confronted through the contamination and responsible-sourcing frameworks; that the Nile and its damaged dams can be safeguarded through the transboundary and dam-safety channels; and that the international, UN, diaspora, and safe-community channels offer real avenues a war-torn state cannot. These tools are general, reaching any of the country's harms, with the gum belt the central case. The levers work largely from outside, and the prize is the belt protected and kept conflict-free, the gold confronted, and the Nile safeguarded — not open confrontation. For a nation at war whose acacia belt is a quiet treasure the whole world depends on, that careful work — pressed from outside, supporting the poor rather than blaming them, and protecting everyone inside absolutely — is not a lesser ambition. It is the only responsible and effective one.